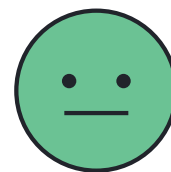
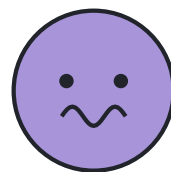
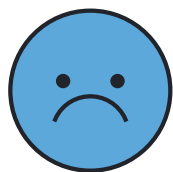




TEEN WELLBEING SEL SERIES



Under Pressure

A Stress & Anxiety Coping Workbook for Teens

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Ages 10-19 - Printable

Home - Classroom - Counseling - Calm Corners

Reproducible for one home or classroom



How to Use This Book

This workbook is made for ages 10 to 19 - a stage packed with change, pressure, and big emotions. It won't talk down to you. Instead, it gives you real tools, honest questions, and space to think for yourself.

There are no grades and no wrong answers. Work at your own pace, be honest in the writing spaces, and come back to the pages that help most. Skills grow with practice.

For Grown-Ups

- ☐ Give privacy - journaling is more honest when it isn't graded or read without permission.
- ☐ Offer to talk, but don't force it; being available matters more than pushing.
- ☐ Model the skills yourself - teens notice what adults actually do.
- ☐ If big feelings feel unmanageable, connect the teen with a counselor or trusted professional.

Tip: There are no wrong answers here. Every feeling is okay. What matters is what we choose to DO with big feelings.



How This Book Works

Each part mixes three things: short explanations of what's going on in your brain and body, self-checks to notice your own patterns, and tools plus reflection to help you respond in ways you feel good about.

Getting the most from it

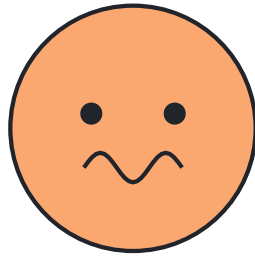
- ☐ Be honest - this is for you, not for show.
- ☐ Try the tools more than once before deciding if they help.
- ☐ Use the trackers to spot patterns over a week or two.
- ☐ Revisit the plans and update them as you learn.

This activity book supports everyday social-emotional learning and self-reflection. It is not therapy or medical advice. If you are struggling with your safety or mental health, please talk to a trusted adult, a counselor, or a local helpline right away.

What's Inside



- 1 Understanding Stress & Anxiety
- 2 My Stress Signals
- 3 Calming the Body
- 4 Calming the Mind
- 5 Managing Pressure
- 6 Reflection & Plan



Part 1: Understanding Stress & Anxiety

Your alarm system, explained.



Stress Isn't All Bad

Stress is your body getting ready to meet a challenge - a pounding heart before a game or a test can actually help you focus. The problem is when the alarm won't switch off, or fires when there's no real danger. That's when stress tips into anxiety.

Anxiety is like a smoke alarm that goes off at burnt toast: the feeling is real, but the danger often isn't as big as it feels. Learning to check 'real threat or false alarm?' is a core skill in this book.

Signs the alarm is overworking

- ☐ Racing thoughts or constant 'what ifs.'
- ☐ Trouble sleeping or relaxing.
- ☐ Avoiding things because they feel scary.
- ☐ Physical stuff: tight chest, stomachaches, tension.



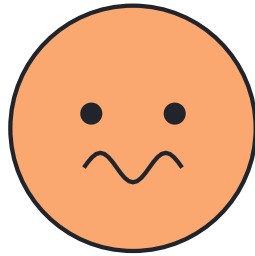
The Stress-Performance Sweet Spot

A little pressure sharpens you; too much overwhelms you. Picture an upside-down U: performance rises with some stress, peaks, then drops as stress becomes too much.

The goal isn't zero stress - it's finding your sweet spot and having tools to come back down when you tip past it.

Coming back to the sweet spot

- ☐ Slow the body first (breathing, movement).
- ☐ Break big tasks into small steps.
- ☐ Challenge 'what if' thoughts with facts.



Part 2: My Stress Signals

Catch it early, handle it easier.



My Stress & Anxiety Check

Rate how often each has been true lately.

1 = Rarely 5 = Very often

My mind races with worries.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

I feel tension or aches in my body.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

I avoid things that make me anxious.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

I have trouble sleeping because of worry.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

I feel on edge or irritable.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Worry gets in the way of school or friends.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

What my answers tell me



My Stress Thermometer

A feelings thermometer shows how BIG a feeling is. Green is calm and okay. Yellow is starting to bubble. Red is a very big feeling. Knowing our level helps us pick the right calm-down tool.



RED - Big feeling



YELLOW - Getting bigger



GREEN - Calm & okay

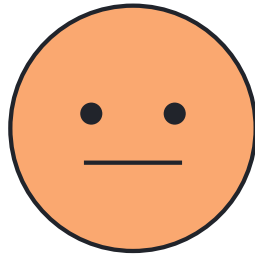
What can I do at each level? Write above.



Stress & Trigger Log

When you feel stressed or overwhelmed, logging it helps you understand your triggers and what actually helps. Fill one row when a stressful moment happens.

- 1** Situation / trigger: _____
Body & feelings (0-10): _____
What I did: _____
Did it help?: _____
- 2** Situation / trigger: _____
Body & feelings (0-10): _____
What I did: _____
Did it help?: _____
- 3** Situation / trigger: _____
Body & feelings (0-10): _____
What I did: _____
Did it help?: _____
- 4** Situation / trigger: _____
Body & feelings (0-10): _____
What I did: _____
Did it help?: _____



Part 3: Calming the Body

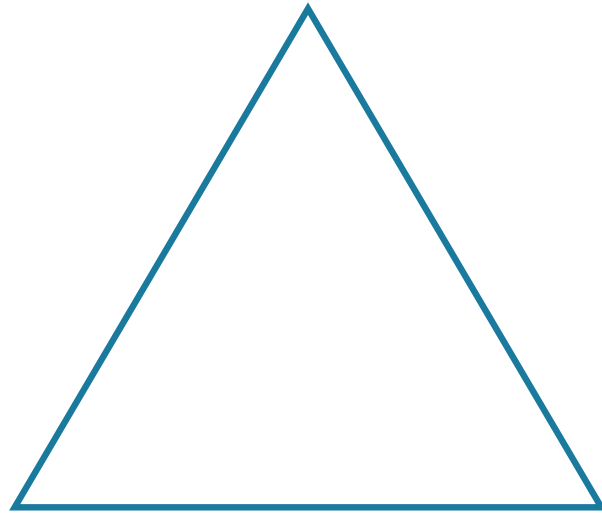
Settle the body and the mind follows.



4-7-8 Breathing

Slow breathing tells our body it is safe. Trace the shape slowly with your finger while you breathe. Do it 3-5 times.

4-7-8 Breathing



1. Breathe in through your nose for 4.
2. Hold gently for 7.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for 8.
4. Repeat 4 times. Great before sleep or a test.



5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

When anxiety spikes, grounding pulls you out of the 'what ifs' and back to right now using your senses. Fill it in the next time you feel anxious.

5 things I can SEE

4 things I can FEEL/TOUCH

3 things I can HEAR

2 things I can SMELL

1 slow BREATH

Calm-the-Body Menu



Tick tools to try; star the ones that help.

Fast resets (under 2 minutes)

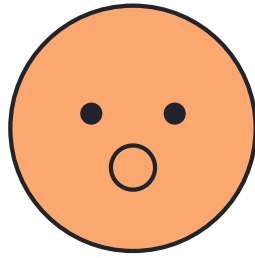
- ☐ Slow breathing: in for 4, out for 6, a few rounds.
- ☐ Cold water on your face or hands.
- ☐ Name 5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch.
- ☐ Unclench your jaw, drop your shoulders, shake out your hands.

Move & release

- ☐ Walk, stretch, or do a few push-ups or jumping jacks.
- ☐ Put on a song and move to it.
- ☐ Squeeze and release your muscles from head to toe.

Longer-term care

- ☐ Keep a steady sleep routine.
- ☐ Limit doom-scrolling before bed.
- ☐ Spend time on something that gives you meaning.



Part 4: Calming the Mind

Worry thoughts aren't facts.



Common Thinking Traps

Everyone's brain falls into 'thinking traps' sometimes. Naming them helps you step back. Circle the ones you notice most, then write an example.

All-or-nothing

Seeing things as total success or total failure, no middle ground.

Catastrophizing

Assuming the worst possible outcome will happen.

Mind-reading

Believing you know others are judging you - without proof.

Labeling

Calling yourself 'stupid' or 'a failure' over one event.

~~A thinking trap I fall into, and a real example:~~

Filtering

Only noticing the negatives and ignoring the positives.

Should statements

Harsh rules like 'I should always...' that set you up to feel bad.



Catch It, Check It, Change It

Our thoughts shape our feelings. Sometimes an automatic thought is unhelpful or untrue. You can CATCH the thought, CHECK if it's fair and true, and CHANGE it into a more balanced one. This is a skill - it gets easier with practice.

1. The situation (just the facts):

2. The automatic thought that popped up:

3. The feeling it gave me (and how strong, 0-10):

4. Check it: Is it 100% true? What's the evidence? Am I mind-reading or catastrophizing?

5. A more balanced, fair thought:

6. How I feel now:

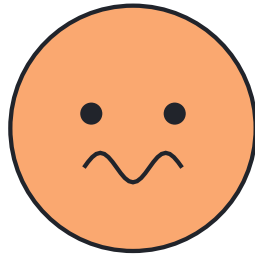


Worry Time & the 'Control' Sort

Two tools that shrink worry: set a short daily 'worry time' so worries don't run all day, and sort worries into what you CAN and CAN'T control - then act only on what you can.

Things I can control

Things I can't control (practice letting these go)



Part 5: Managing Pressure

Handle real pressures with a plan.



Pressure Situations (1)

Read each situation. There are many good choices! Think it through, then write or draw what you could do to stay calm and kind.

- 1** You have three deadlines and a test in the same week.

What could you do?

- 2** You feel panicky before speaking or performing in front of people.

What could you do?

- 3** You're lying awake at night with a racing mind.

What could you do?



Pressure Situations (2)

Read each situation. There are many good choices! Think it through, then write or draw what you could do to stay calm and kind.

1 You feel pressure to be perfect and it's exhausting.

What could you do?

2 Everyone seems to have it together except you.

What could you do?

3 A big decision is stressing you out.

What could you do?



My Anti-Stress Toolkit Plan

Build your go-to plan for stressful stretches.

My earliest stress signals are:

Body-calming tools I'll use:

Mind-calming tools I'll use:

How I'll break big tasks down:

My Personal Wellbeing Plan



Pull it all together. This is your go-to plan when things get hard.

My early warning signs that a feeling is getting big:

My top 3 tools that actually work for me:

People I can reach out to (and how):

Kind, true things I can tell myself:

One habit that helps me feel steady:



When You Need More Help

Some feelings are too big to handle alone - and that's not weakness, it's human. Reaching out is a strong, smart move.

Reach out if...

- ☐ A feeling won't ease up for days, or keeps getting worse.
- ☐ You're avoiding things you used to enjoy.
- ☐ You have thoughts of hurting yourself or others.
- ☐ You just need someone to talk to - that's reason enough.

Who I can reach out to

If you ever feel unsafe or think about hurting yourself, tell a trusted adult now or contact a local emergency number or crisis/helpline in your country right away. You deserve support.



What Matters to Me

Knowing what matters to you makes decisions and hard days easier. When you act in line with your values, stress often makes more sense and feels more manageable.

Three values that matter most to me

One goal that fits those values

One small step I can take this week



Checking In With Myself

What's one thing I'm handling better than I used to?

What still feels hard, and what might help?



Saying It: Boundary Scripts

A boundary is a limit that protects your wellbeing. Boundaries can be kind AND firm. Practice wording so it's ready when you need it.

Saying no without over-explaining: "No thanks, that doesn't work for me." My version:

Asking for space: "I need some time to myself right now." My version:

Naming a limit online: "Please don't share that." My version:

Asking for what I need: "It would help me if..." My version:



A Letter to Future Me

Write a short letter to yourself six months from now.

What do you hope is different? What do you want to remember?



Good Things Worth Noticing

Noticing good things helps calm our minds and lift our mood. It doesn't erase hard feelings, but it reminds us that good things are here too.

Three good things about today

Someone I'm thankful for - and why

Draw something that makes you smile:

A large, empty rectangular box with rounded corners and a thin grey border, intended for drawing.

My Notes & Reflections



Lined area for notes and reflections, consisting of 20 horizontal lines.



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